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Wax & gold

Author(S): Levine, Donald Nathan

Document Type: Book

Original Page: 255

Culture (OWC): [Amhara \(MP05\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: 1958-1961

Coverage Date: 1270-1961

Place Coverage: Ethiopia

Section Title(S): Self And Others

It is true that the forms of respect toward superiors are often repeated mechanically and sometimes serve to cover up a distinctly hostile disposition toward certain superiors. They nevertheless do respect to some extent a genuine solidaristic sentiment—perhaps the most profound and influential social sentiment in the Amhara social system. It rests in the last analysis on the fact that the Amhara family develops a pronounced sense of filial devotion as well as habits of filial obedience. Amhara society can dispense with horizontal solidarities and communal attachments because it is held together, sufficiently for traditional purposes, at least, by an infinite network of “father-son” relationships.

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The egoistic element in the hierarchical pattern is further modified by a sort of joking relationship that sometimes develops between inferiors and superiors. The harsh interrogation of inferiors at times shades into a sort of wry banter; sons or servants may be called “thief” or “scoundrel” in an undertone of unmistakable affection. At times, moreover, the direction of the jesting may be reversed. Amhara servants are noted for playing practical jokes on their masters, which the latter usually appreciate when the jests are clever. ²²⁷

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Here again, wax and gold is the perfect medium—for expressing aggression against a superior while at the same time appearing to maintain the respect relationship. The following couplet, attributed to Naggadr[unknown]as Tassama Eshate, aptly illustrates this genre:

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Ennanta maku[unknown]annentotch ba-mîn wat balatchu?
Eññam ba-shurw[unknown]atchen enn[unknown]antam bass[unknown]atchu
 .

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What sauce, my lords, was on your plate?
 We had but peas; 'twas fish you ate. ²²⁸

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Here the poet appears to be complimenting the nobles on their more elegant cuisine at a banquet; but there is a pun on the word *bass[unknown]atchu*, literally "with your fish," for it may also be taken to mean "you took more than your share."

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Within the hierarchical pattern, finally, one finds expressed a certain amount of generosity which, as we have suggested, is relatively uncommon in relations among peers. This appears in connection with the *begging* and *almsgiving* which occur in many sectors of Amhara society. For church students beyond the elementary level, begging is the primary means of livelihood. Youths who have left home to study *zema* or *qene* with a master wander about today, as in former times, carrying small baskets and pleading: "For the sake of Mary! For the sake of God!" in order to get their daily morsels. The activity is so organized that when a large number of students ■256 live near the same master, they divide up the neighboring countryside to avoid duplication in their begging.

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. Cf. J. I. Eadie, *An Amharic Reader* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1924), pp. 39-46.

. Mahtama-Selassie Walda-Masqal, *Amar[unknown]iñña Qene* (Addis Ababa, 1948 E.C.), p. 53.

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